EXAM MECHANICS · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam mechanics and clock management

Cross-cutting. The rules, the clock, and what this course found that most material has not.

TYPE Cross-cutting TIME 120 min TOPIC Exam day

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The exam at a glance

	DETAIL
Questions	59 scored, multiple choice.
Time	120 minutes.
Fee	USD 200, plus local taxes.
Delivery	Online proctored, or test centre proctored.
Test aids	None. Explicitly including API documentation.
Prerequisite	None required. One year of hands-on experience is recommended.
Validity	2 years, then recertify on the current version.

ON THE EXAM

No pass mark is published anywhere in the guide. Aim to be comfortable rather than to hit a number.

Unscored items, and what they do to your budget

- The exam **may include unscored items**, used to gather statistics for future versions.
- They are **not identified on the form**. You cannot tell which they are, and you should not try.
- They do **not affect your score**, and **additional time is factored in** for them.
- So do not budget 120 divided by 59. Budget roughly **two minutes per question you actually see**.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The arithmetic people do in their heads is slightly wrong, and in your favour. There are more questions and more time than 59 and 120 suggest.

Where the marks actually are

SECTION	WEIGHT
1. Developing code for data processing	22%
6. Cost and performance optimization	13%
3, 5, 7, 9. Transformation, monitoring, security, deploying	10% each
2, 8. Ingestion, governance	7% each
10. Data modeling	6%
4. Data sharing and federation	5%

ON THE EXAM

Section 1 alone is more than a fifth of the paper. If revision time is short, that is where it goes.

The guide changes, and it tells you so

- The guide says directly: **check back two weeks before your exam** to make sure you have the current version.
- This course is built on the version live as of **3 July 2026**.
- Objectives get reworded, renamed and reweighted. It has happened repeatedly in the last year.
- Two minutes of checking beats an afternoon of studying an objective that has moved.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Databricks publishes guide updates ahead of the change taking effect, so a check tells you what is coming as well as what is current.

What Databricks recommends studying

- Instructor-led: **Advanced Data Engineering With Databricks**.
- Self-paced: **Advanced Techniques with Spark Declarative Pipeline**, **Databricks Data Privacy**, **Databricks Performance Optimization**, and **Automated Deployment with Bundles**.
- Those four map onto **Sections 1, 7, 6 and 9**, which are three of the four heaviest sections.
- Treat the list as a statement about emphasis rather than a required reading list.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Databricks chose four self-paced courses out of everything it publishes. Which four is itself information.

Two minutes, and what that buys

- Two minutes is **plenty** for a question you know, and **not enough** for one you are reasoning out from scratch.
- So the budget is really: bank time on the ones you know, and spend it on the ones you do not.
- The failure mode is spending six minutes on question four and then rushing the last fifteen.
- Aim to reach the halfway point with **more than half the time left**.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Everyone knows this and it is still the most common way people lose marks they had already earned.

Three passes, not one

- **First pass:** answer everything you are confident about, and **flag anything that takes more than about ninety seconds**.
- **Second pass:** return to the flagged ones with the clock in hand and a calmer head.
- **Third pass:** if time remains, revisit only those you flagged as genuinely uncertain.
- **Always answer everything.** There is no penalty for a wrong answer, so an unanswered question is a wasted one.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The flag exists so you can leave a question without deciding you have failed it. Use it early and often.

Find the requirement sentence first

- Most scenarios contain **one clause that decides the answer**. Find it before reading the options.
- Examples from this course: **without rearranging the data**, **without failing the job**, **must not be subject to the regulation**.
- Also: **latency under 400 milliseconds**, **the team is comfortable in SQL**, **no constraint requires hand-written streaming**.
- Reading the options first invites you to justify one, rather than to test all four against the requirement.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Reading the options before the requirement is the single most expensive habit in a multiple-choice exam.

How the wrong answers are usually wrong

- **Right technique, wrong layer.** A real tool applied one level away from the problem.
- **True but irrelevant.** A correct statement that does not address the requirement.
- **Right conclusion, wrong reason.** Reaches the correct answer through a false claim.
- **Outdated but formerly correct.** True two years ago, and this course has met several.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Notice that none of these is nonsense. Every category is something a competent engineer might say.

Things that changed, part one

- **Delta Sharing is now OpenSharing.** Renamed 10 June 2026, three weeks before the guide, which still says delta sharing.
- **The pipelines Python API was renamed** a week after the guide. The import, the decorators and the change capture function all changed.
- **ABAC row filters and column masks went GA** in May 2026, and the docs now recommend them. The guide names only the table-level form.
- **The change data feed table property is now described as legacy.** An automatic form exists.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Four renames or repositions the guide has not absorbed. In each case, answer with what the guide names and know what is current.

Things that changed, part two

- **The 32-column statistics limit now applies only to external tables.** Managed tables under predictive optimization have no limit.
- **Predictive optimization does not run ZORDER, and ignores Z-ordered files.** A tuned table gets less maintenance, not more.
- **Liquid clustering replaces partitioning and ZORDER**, and is recommended for all new tables.
- **Asset Bundles are now Declarative Automation Bundles.** This one the guide did catch.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Where the guide and the docs disagree, answer the guide's language and know the docs' position. Both appear in questions.

The week before

- **Check the guide** for a newer version. Two minutes, and it is the highest-value thing on this list.
- Work the three practice exams in this course under timed conditions, not as a reading exercise.
- Revisit **module 34**. Confusion pairs are where marks are won and lost.
- Do not start a new topic in the last three days. Consolidate what you have.

> ON THE EXAM
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> If you have one hour left, spend it on Section 1 and on the confusion pairs, in that order.

Practical things that go wrong

- For an online proctored exam, test your setup **the day before**, not fifteen minutes beforehand.
- Clear your desk completely. Proctors are strict, and a delay here eats your exam time.
- Read every option before answering, even when the first one looks obviously right.
- If your mind goes blank, **flag it and move on**. The next question often unlocks it.

> ON THE EXAM
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> None of this is clever. It is the list of things that cost people marks for reasons unrelated to what they know.

What to carry into the exam

- **59 scored questions, 120 minutes, no test aids.** Unscored items exist with extra time allowed.
- **Section 1 is 22%.** If revision time is short, that is where it goes.
- **Three passes.** Flag anything over ninety seconds. Answer everything; there is no penalty.
- **Find the requirement sentence before reading the options.**
- **Check the guide two weeks before.** It changes, and it tells you to.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Three practice exams follow. Work them timed, and treat a wrong answer as the most useful thing on the page.